

MEG – 15

Q1. Cultural Diversity in the Contemporary World and the Role of Cultural Studies (20)

Cultural diversity is one of the most defining features of the contemporary world. In present times, societies across the globe are no longer culturally uniform. Instead, they consist of people belonging to different religions, ethnic groups, languages, traditions, lifestyles, and belief systems. Advances in technology, globalisation, migration, international trade, and mass media have brought cultures into close contact, making cultural diversity an unavoidable and visible reality.

Cultural diversity refers to the coexistence of multiple cultures within a society or across nations. Culture itself includes not only art, literature, and music, but also everyday practices such as food habits, dress, rituals, language, customs, and social behaviour. In the contemporary world, cultural diversity enriches human experience by encouraging creativity, dialogue, and mutual learning. Exposure to different cultures broadens perspectives and promotes tolerance.

However, cultural diversity also presents challenges. Conflicts often arise when dominant cultures attempt to impose their values on minority groups. Issues such as racism, religious intolerance, cultural stereotyping, and marginalisation are common in multicultural societies. Globalisation sometimes leads to cultural homogenisation, where local traditions are overshadowed by global consumer culture dominated by Western influences.

This complex situation makes cultural studies extremely important. Cultural studies is an interdisciplinary field that examines culture as a site of power, conflict, and negotiation. Unlike traditional approaches that focus only on elite culture, cultural studies include popular culture, media, everyday life, and marginalised voices.

Cultural studies help us understand how culture is shaped by factors such as class, gender, race, colonial history, and economic power. For example, films, television, advertisements, and social media are analysed to understand how identities are constructed and how ideologies are promoted or challenged.

Another important contribution of cultural studies is that it questions who controls cultural representation. It highlights how certain groups are silenced or misrepresented and encourages resistance against cultural domination. Postcolonial cultural studies, in particular, examine how colonial legacies continue to influence cultural identities.

Thus, in a culturally diverse contemporary world, cultural studies provide tools to critically understand culture not as static or innocent, but as dynamic, political, and deeply connected to power relations.

Q2. Jean Rhys' *Wide Sargasso Sea* as a Postcolonial Text (20)

Jean Rhys' *Wide Sargasso Sea* is one of the most influential postcolonial novels of the twentieth century. It is a reworking of Charlotte Brontë's *Jane Eyre*, focusing on the character of Bertha Mason, the so-called "madwoman in the attic." Rhys rewrites the colonial story from the perspective of the colonised, giving voice to a character who was silenced and marginalised in the original text.

As a postcolonial novel, *Wide Sargasso Sea* examines the effects of colonialism on identity, race, gender, and culture. Antoinette Cosway, the protagonist, is a Creole woman living in the Caribbean after the abolition of slavery. She belongs to neither the white British colonisers nor the Black Jamaican community. This in-between position creates a deep sense of alienation and identity crisis.

The novel strongly critiques colonial power through the character of Rochester. He represents the coloniser's attitude of superiority and control. His inability to understand Caribbean culture, landscape, and people reflects colonial ignorance. By renaming Antoinette as "Bertha," he symbolically erases her identity, asserting patriarchal and colonial authority.

Rhys also challenges colonial representations of the Caribbean. Instead of exoticising the landscape, she presents it as emotionally charged and psychologically intense. Nature reflects Antoinette's inner turmoil and the violent history of colonisation.

Narrative technique plays a key role in establishing the novel as postcolonial. The use of multiple narrators and fragmented structure reflects the instability of identity in a colonised society. Language itself becomes a site of conflict, with English failing to fully express Caribbean experience.

By rewriting *Jane Eyre* from a postcolonial perspective, *Wide Sargasso Sea* exposes the racial and gender politics of imperialism and restores dignity to a silenced voice. It is therefore a powerful example of postcolonial re-visioning.

Q3. Why Autobiography Is Often Described as Fiction (20)

Autobiography is generally defined as the life story of an individual written by the person themselves. Traditionally, it has been regarded as a factual and truthful genre. However, many modern critics argue that autobiography shares several characteristics with fiction, leading to the claim that it is a form of imaginative narrative.

One of the main reasons for this view is the subjectivity of memory. Human memory is selective and unreliable. An autobiographer chooses certain events while ignoring others. Past experiences are interpreted through present understanding, emotions, and beliefs. As a result, the life presented in an autobiography is shaped rather than recorded.

Autobiographies also use fictional techniques such as narrative structure, characterisation, dialogue, and symbolism. The author often presents their life as a coherent story with a beginning, development, and resolution, even though real life is often disorganised and contradictory.

Another important aspect is self-representation. Autobiographers may consciously or unconsciously present themselves in a favourable light, justifying actions or emphasising achievements. This process of self-fashioning blurs the boundary between fact and imagination.

Language itself contributes to fictionalisation. When lived experiences are transformed into words, they become representations rather than reality. Emotional truth may take precedence over factual accuracy.

Therefore, critics do not argue that autobiography is false, but that it is constructed truth. It lies between history and fiction, combining personal experience with narrative creativity. This is why autobiography is often described as a fictionalised version of reality.

Q4. Magical Realism and Folk Tales (20)

Magical realism is a literary mode in which magical or supernatural elements are presented as part of ordinary reality. Interestingly, many of its features can be found in traditional folk tales, especially those belonging to non-Western cultures.

Folk tales often include extraordinary elements such as talking animals, spirits, gods, shape-shifting characters, and magical transformations. These events are accepted naturally by characters within the story. There is no sense of surprise or disbelief, which closely resembles the technique of magical realism.

In folk narratives, the magical and the real coexist without conflict. This reflects cultural worldviews where the spiritual and material worlds are interconnected. Magical realism similarly challenges Western rationalism by presenting reality as layered and complex.

Folk tales also serve social and moral purposes. Through symbolic storytelling, they convey cultural values, collective memory, and historical experiences. Magical realism uses the same method to explore issues such as colonial trauma, oppression, and identity.

Thus, folk tales can be seen as early forms of magical realism. Both rely on myth, symbolism, and oral tradition to express truths that cannot be conveyed through realism alone.

Q5. Comparison of *The Palm-Wine Drinkard* and *The Famished Road* (20)

Amos Tutuola's *The Palm-Wine Drinkard* and Ben Okri's *The Famished Road* are two important African novels that draw heavily from indigenous oral traditions. Although written decades apart, both texts explore the relationship between the physical and spiritual worlds.

The Palm-Wine Drinkard is structured like a folktale. The narrative is episodic and simple, following the hero's journey through a world filled with spirits, monsters, and magical events. The language is direct and reflects oral storytelling techniques.

The Famished Road is more complex and lyrical. It follows Azaro, a spirit-child, and blends magical realism with political commentary. The novel reflects the struggles of postcolonial Nigeria, including poverty, corruption, and social instability.

While Tutuola's novel focuses more on myth and adventure, Okri's work combines myth with psychological depth and political awareness. Both novels, however, challenge Western realism and affirm African ways of understanding reality.

Together, these works highlight the richness of African storytelling and its ability to represent cultural identity, history, and resistance.
